

IK 526: Kalā and Nāṭyaśāstra

Course Code	IK 526
Course Name	Kalā and Nāṭyaśāstra
L-T-P-C	2.5-0-1-3
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	M.A/ B. Tech/MTech/MS/MSc/PhD
Mutual Exclusion	There are no equivalent or overlapping courses across schools.
Approval	64th BoA (May 2026)

Preamble

This course introduces students to the foundational theories, practices, and cultural contexts of Indian arts, including classical music, dance, theatre, visual arts, and puppetry. It explores aesthetic principles such as rasa, the influence of sacred texts, and the socio-cultural frameworks shaping traditional and contemporary art forms along with few practical components. The course also examines regional practices, intangible cultural heritage, and systems such as tāla, laya, and kaṭapayādi.

Course Modules

- **Module 1: Foundations of Indian Aesthetics:** (9 hours)
 - Overview of Indian Music, classical dance traditions of India, Theatre art forms, Indian painting traditions.
 - Introduction to the term folk, tribal and modern art forms of India.
 - Concept of Navarasa and aesthetic experience
 - An account of the traditional art forms and cultural festivals of India as represented in UN-ESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage (ICH)
- **Module 2: Indian Classical Music Systems:** (9 hours)
 - Hindustani & Carnatic music: structure and classification
 - Major forms in Carnatic music & Hindustani traditions
 - Concepts of Tāla and Laya and chhanda
 - Concept of a complete Sangeet (A marriage between Sur, Tāla and Kāvya)
 - Kaṭapayādi system in Melakarta rāga classification
 - Evolution from Caturdaṇḍi to modern Carnatic concert paddhati
 - Practical demonstration and analysis of a few Hindustani and Carnatic musical forms
- **Module 3: Classical Dance / Theatre Traditions:** (9 hours)
 - Overview of the eight classical dance forms: Bharatanatyam, Mohiniyattam, Kathakali, Kuchipudi, Kathak, Odissi, Manipuri, Sattriya
 - Introduction to Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra & Overview of Abhinaya Darpaṇa
 - Introduction to regional theatre practise- Yakshagana, Chhau, Jatra, Theyyam, Koodiyattam, Bhaona, etc.
 - Socio-cultural context – Folk, tribal, traditional & ritualistic performances
 - Practical demonstration and analysis of a few Indian traditional dance forms and how abhinaya (theatre) is inherently related to it or Body acting based theatre workshop

• **Module 4: Texts and Visual Traditions:** (9 hours)

- Influence of Gīta Govinda, Rāmāyaṇa, Mahābhārata in Indian Dance and Paintings
- Indian painting traditions: Madhubani, Pattachitra, Pahari, Kalamkari
- Interrelation between literature and visual culture
- Practical demonstration and analysis of a few Indian traditional visual art forms or Workshop on various visual cultures of India

• **Module 5: Puppetry and Narrative Traditions:** (6 hours)

- Types of Indian puppetry: Kathputli, Tholu Bommalata, Ravana Chhaya, Tolpavakoothu
- Influence of Panchatantra and oral storytelling traditions & Kath Kālkṣepam
- Practical demonstration and analysis of a few Indian puppetry forms or Workshop on storytelling and various ancient texts of India

Text Books

- a. Sambamurthy. P, *South Indian Music*, Vol: 1-13, Indian Music Publishing House, Madras, 1973
- b. Ananda K. Coomaraswamy. *The Dance of Śiva: Essays on Indian Art and Culture*. New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal.

References

- a. Seetha s. *Taṇjāvūr as a Seat of Music*. University of Madras, 2001.
- b. *Traditional Indian Theatre*. New Delhi: National Book Trust, 1974.
- c. *Ajanta*. Oxford University Press, 1930–1955.
- d. *The Hindu Temple*. Calcutta: University of Calcutta, 1946.
- e. *The Nāṭyaśāstra: A Treatise on Ancient Indian Dramaturgy and Histrionics*. Edited by Manomohan Ghosh. Calcutta: Manisha Granthalaya.
- f. *Dasarupaka*. Translated by George C. O. Haas. New York: Columbia University Press, 1912.
- g. Erin B. Mee (ed.). *Theatres of India: A Concise Companion*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.
- h. P. Sambamoorthy. *The Splendour of South Indian Music*. Madras: The Indian Music Publishing House.
- i. Richard Widdess. *The Rāgas of Early Indian Music: Modes, Melodies and Musical Notations from the Gupta Period to c.1250*. Oxford University Press.